

FASHION ICON
[1, 3] Zeenat Aman (*Satyam Shivam Sundaram)* and Ben Kingsley and Rohini Hattangadi (*Gandhi*) in Athaiya's costumes; [2] Athaiya's sketches for a fashion spread in *Eve's Weekly*; [4] the designer herself at the Oscars in 1983

Candolim in Goa. Organised by art auction house Prinseps, which acquired Athaiya's estate, it looks to offer an insight into a woman who donned many hats, and each with aplomb.

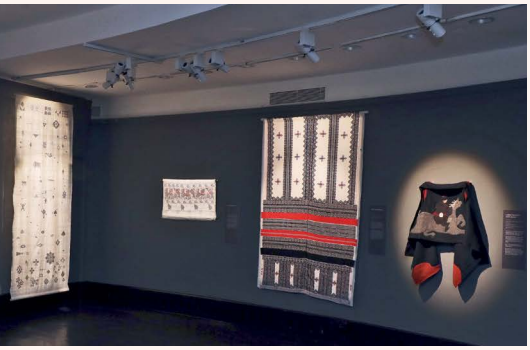
For exhibition curator Princess Brijeshwari Kumari Gohil, Bhavnagar, the warehouse showed how "meticulous a scholar" Athaiya was in how she "kept everything", be it her mother's hand-woven saris or the contract she signed with the makers of *Gandhi* to claim ownership of certain costumes. "We knew an online auction [conducted in December 2020] won't do justice to her legacy," says Gohil. "There needs to be a conversation about her and greater awareness of her body of work. There's so much she has left behind to learn from."

The very first exhibition was held in the capital, for only five days. The one in Goa, says Gohil, doesn't just run longer but is also bigger in the array of objects that it will showcase. Divided into parts, it begins with Athaiya's years as a young girl in the princely state of Kolhapur, followed by her arrival in Bombay to study art where she would become the only woman artist of the Progressive Artists' Group. After dabbling in illustration with fashion magazines, she would rise to become a sought-after costume designer in Hindi cinema. Says Gohil, "You see her love and vision for India and how it differed through different chapters of her life and how it inspired her." Athaiya would go on to design uniforms for Air India staff too.

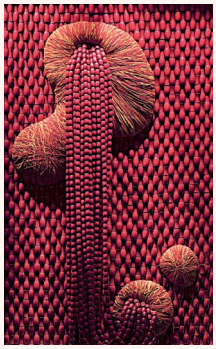
Gohil, who undertook the mammoth task of archiving and digitising Athaiya's work during the COVID-19 pandemic, hopes that the exhibition is an eye-opener in the role Athaiya played in defining fashion in India. "There are so many designs trending in India that in some ways are inspired by her," she says, citing stretch churidars and the way saris were draped. "You are looking at a time when movies were the only way for people to be influenced by fashion. She was an influencer before 'influencer' became a word."

Unlike today's influencers, though, Athaiya wasn't the most media-savvy person and let her work do the talking. "Her designers were glamorous, but she didn't put herself out there," says Gohil. Athaiya's creations for actresses like Waheeda Rehman, Sharmila Tagore, Sadhana, Mumtaz, Vyjayanthimala, Hema Malini, Rekha and Zeenat Aman would set sartorial trends. She quickly became a favourite among her heroines. "Bhanuji was ahead of her time; she could create clothes that made you look sexy and sensual yet not vulgar; something that enhanced your figure," Rekha recalled in an article for the Prinseps website. The exhibition will also see Aman recalling her stint with the designer who dressed her in *Satyam Shivam Sundaram*, among other films, in a talk scheduled on December 13. Gohil's aim is to bring the exhibition to the city Athaiya called home—Bombay a.k.a. Mumbai. "A lot of work from people at the back end of things gets forgotten," says Gohil. This exhibition ensures that Athaiya's legacy stays alive. ■

Suhani Singh







WOVEN LEGACY
Snapshots from *Sutr Santati: Then.Now.Next*

manner, reflecting the considerations of its present venue," says Baldota.

Interestingly, *Sutr Santati* also stands out for its intent—to offer equal opportunity to both established and upcoming artists. "My endeavour is to provide inspiration and encouragement to the young generation of artisans and designers to value our textile heritage and take it forward. Bringing them together on the same platform also forges new collaborations, while providing creative dignity to the artisans," says Baldota.

This year, the exhibition seeks to promote organic, slow consumerism, with 75 specially commissioned artworks that utilise a range of indigenous fibres like Kandu and Kala cotton, mulberry and wild silks, camel and sheep wool, etc.

While there's much to see at the exhibition, there are a few artworks Baldota reckons have never been seen before. "The Kodallikaruppur revival panel by Aksh Studio is a must-see. After the 19th century, this kind of revival in this textile has happened for the first time. The very fine *chikankari* embroidery by Tapas Studio, the chintz section with works by Renuka Reddy and the embroidered panels by Purvi Patel, the installation of 'Infinite Fields' by Studio Moonray and 'Manka Moli' by Ashiesh Shah," she says. ■

Geetika Sachdev